Myanmar's prehistory begins with the emergence of the Paleolithic Anyathian culture along the Ayeyarwaddy valley in Upper Myanmar. Radiocarbon dating places prehistoric human habitation as far back as 11,000 BCE. Very little is known about the Anyathian culture. What is known comes from the six kinds of hand tools that have been discovered in the 14 archaeological sites along Ayeyarwaddy associated with the Anyathian culture. Additional archaeological evidence suggests the Anyathian were hunter-gatherers who survived by hunting wild animals and foraging wild fruits and vegetables.

The assemblage of stone tools from Anyathian sites bear close resemblance to finds in the Soan site in northeast India and the Choukoutienian sites of China, as well as the Lalmai Hills and Chaklapunji sites in Bangladesh. The technological similarities and distribution of fossil wood assemblages suggest a shared cultural tradition throughout much of Southeast Asia during the prehistoric period. This suggests that there was meaningful contact over a wide area of Southeast Asia that would continue into later historical periods.

Systematic archaeological excavations by the Department of Archaeology, Ministry of Culture, have led to the discovery of cave paintings and stone tools in the Padahlin caves in Ywogen township on the southern Shan plateau. Radiocarbon analysis of the stone tools dates occupation of the caves from 10,000 BCE to 6000 BCE, a period that encompasses both the Paleolithic and the Neolithic periods. The Padahlin caves were the scene of intermittent human habitation for around 4,000 years. The crude pottery shards and stone rings found at Padahlin appear to have been attached to stonecutting tools suggesting that they were used for digging. Archaeologists speculate that the tools were probably used to clear patches of forest for cultivation that would indicate the shift from hunter-gatherers to cultivated agriculture had begun by the late Neolithic period in Myanmar. As with the polished stone rings found at Ban Lum Khuo and Ban Na Di in Thailand, the stone rings had been drilled with small holes and repaired with bronze wire.

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